D'var Torah on Parshas Mishpatim: The Cycle of Growth

Introduction: A Daughter's Question

All right, Erev Shabbos, Parshas Mishpatim. I want to start with a story.

I've learned under, and with some amazing people. My children know this too—they know how to show that kavod, as we spoke about last week. One of the people I have the privilege to learn with and learn from is Rabbi Dan Channen. My children also know Rabbi Dan, and they like him very much. Before I learn with him, my daughter will sometimes ask me to ask Rabbi Dan something.

This week was no exception. Before my learning with him, she asked, "Tati, why do we keep kosher?"

Most of us already have our answers. Because Hashem says so. Because it's good for us. Because the Torah says this or that. We also have modern justifications for kashrut—health reasons, spiritual reasons, scientific explanations.

When I spoke with Rabbi Dan about it, I still need to relay his full response to my daughter. But it got me thinking about something deeper.

We Are What We Eat

If you know me, you know I say: "We are what we eat."

I've seen this firsthand when traveling to other countries for business. People who eat chazir, pork, often act like chazir—they shove food in their faces, hand over fist, without pause, without dignity. Not everyone is like this, of course, but it's a trend I've observed. There's a coarseness, a lack of refinement in how they relate to food and, by extension, to the world.

Even within the kosher world, some people don't eat properly. They don't eat in a way that shows kavod, respect and dignity. The food might be kosher, but the way they consume it is not elevated.

The Tanya (Iggeres HaKodesh, Chapter 1) discusses how even something kosher or mutar, permitted, can become assur, forbidden, in the way that you treat it. If you eat with gluttony, with no awareness, with no intention to elevate the physical into the spiritual, then even kosher food can pull you down rather than lift you up.

I mention this because it reminds me of another teaching from my rebbe, Rabbi Yehoshua Gerzi.

Refining Our Middos: The Upward Cycle

Rabbi Gerzi teaches that we are metaken, we fix and refine our middos, our character traits, so that our middos are metaken on us. When we do teshuvah, when we learn and grow, when we work on ourselves, these growth perspectives—these values—become part of who we are. And then they lift us even higher.

It's a cycle. We refine our lower selves so we can reach a higher state. And then our higher self brings our lower self even higher. And the cycle continues, spiraling upward.

The Gemara in Yoma (39a) teaches: "הבא ליטהר מסייעין אותו," One who comes to purify himself receives assistance from Heaven. When we make the effort to grow, to refine, to elevate, Hashem helps us. Our own efforts create a vessel for Divine assistance, which enables even greater growth.

I'm mentioning this now because, apart from being the question my daughter asked Rabbi Dan this week, it connects directly to this week's parsha.

Three Categories of Mitzvos

This week's parsha is Parshas Mishpatim. The word "mishpatim" is significant from a halachic perspective because it refers to one of the three categories of mitzvos.

The Gemara in Yoma (67b) explains these three types:

Chukim are mitzvos that don't seem to make rational sense—like the laws of kashrus, shatnez (not mixing wool and linen), or the red heifer. These are statutes we do simply because Hashem commanded them, even though we don't fully understand the reasons.

Edot are mitzvos where we are witnesses, where we testify to something. Like lighting Chanukah candles, which testify to the miracle. Like Shabbos, which testifies that Hashem created the world in six days and rested on the seventh. These mitzvos commemorate and bear testimony.

Mishpatim are the easiest to justify or validate from a rational perspective. These are the social laws, the interpersonal commandments. Don't steal. Don't cheat. Pay your workers on time. What happens if my ox damages your property. These are the laws between one person and another—bein adam lechavero.

And this week's parsha is called Mishpatim.

Rashi's Connection: Same Level, Same Source

Rashi makes a powerful commentary right at the beginning of the parsha. He asks: Why does Parshas Mishpatim come immediately after Parshas Yitro, immediately after the giving of the Torah and the Aseres HaDibros, the Ten Commandments?

Rashi answers (Shemos 21:1): "מה מעלה זו נאמרה מסיני אף אלו נאמרו מסיני," Just as the previous section was stated from Sinai, so too these were stated from Sinai.

The highest standard and values of the Ten Commandments, which came directly from Hashem at Sinai—"אנכי ה' אלקיך," I am Hashem your God—are on the exact same level as the laws about how we interact with each other. The laws about returning lost objects, paying damages, treating workers fairly—these too were given at Sinai. These too are direct Divine commandments.

This is not a minor point. This is transformative.

Higher Self, Lower Self: The Same Playing Field

Another way to look at it: my highest self, my spiritual self that comes from godliness, my nefesh Elokit, connects with the Ten Commandments. "Anochi Hashem Elokecha"—I am Hashem your God. "Lo yihiyeh lecha"—You shall have no other gods. These are the mitzvos from the highest level, mitzvos bein adam laMakom, between man and God.

The Tanya (Chapter 2) teaches: "נפש האלקית חלק אלוקה ממעל ממש," The Divine soul is literally a part of God from above. Our highest self is a spark of the Divine, directly connected to Hashem.

But the Torah is telling us something radical here: those lofty spiritual mitzvos are on the same playing field as how we interact with other people. The seemingly "lower" mitzvos of bein adam lechavero are equal in importance, equal in holiness, equal in their Divine source.

Because it's easy—so easy—to focus on how we daven, how we speak to Hashem, our limud Torah, our spiritual practices, as the highest priorities. And to disregard, to minimize, to push aside how we interact with other people. We might want to deal only with the "spiritual" and not with the messy, complicated reality of human relationships.

But the Torah is telling us: refine your lower self. Your interactions with people are critically important to Hashem. When we work on our lower middos, our interpersonal character traits, Hashem is metaken us, Hashem refines us in return.

Building Up Through Others

If I build the social structure of Mishpatim properly—if I interact with others in the right way, with honesty, fairness, compassion, respect—then those people will also give me the koach, the strength and ability, to grow myself even higher.

My friends, my social circle, my peers, the people I do business with, the people I live among—they help me grow upward. They become part of my spiritual development. It's not just that I'm being nice to them. It's that by treating them properly, I'm building the foundation for my own growth.

This is a great starting point, this recognition that the "lower" is actually essential to reaching the "higher."

Even Slavery: The Torah's Standard

We can even look at how the parsha discusses interactions with others in ways that challenge modern sensibilities. The Torah opens Mishpatim with laws about slavery (Shemos 21:2): "כי תקנה עבד עברי שש שנים יעבד ובשביעת יצא לחפשי חנם," When you acquire a Hebrew servant, he shall work for six years, and in the seventh he shall go free without payment.

From a Western perspective, when people hear the term "slavery," they think of something very low, something inherently degrading and evil.

But the truth is that even in this system, there was still kavod in how we dealt with it. The Rambam in Hilchos Avadim explains extensive laws protecting the dignity and welfare of servants. The Gemara in Kiddushin (20a) teaches: "כל הקונה עבד עברי כקונה אדון לעצמו," Whoever acquires a Hebrew servant is like acquiring a master for himself—because the master must provide for the servant's needs, must treat him with dignity, must ensure he has what he needs.

How we treat employees or those who work for us today—the Torah holds us to a higher standard. Slavery in Jewish times wasn't a good thing, but it wasn't the kind of horrific evil that existed elsewhere, because we had the Torah's guiding light. That ensured we stayed within a healthy reality and perspective. We were showing kavod to other people and, by extension, to Hashem, who created and loves them.

The Gemara in Bava Metzia (112a) records that workers must be paid on time: "ביומו תתן שכרו," On his day you shall give his wages (Devarim 24:15). Delaying payment, even by one day, violates this commandment. This is how seriously the Torah takes our obligations to those who work for us.

The Cycle of Growth Through Mishpatim

By continuously showing kavod to others, we find that the lower refines the higher. It's not a one-way street where we descend to deal with mundane matters and then return to spirituality. Rather, by engaging properly with the mundane, we elevate ourselves and prepare ourselves for higher spiritual levels.

Throughout the parsha, all the mitzvos begin within this perspective: the lower self being built up to the higher through mishpatim. The laws of interpersonal conduct create the foundation.

And then, as the parsha progresses, we eventually reach a higher point. Now we can start interacting with other types of mitzvos again—chukim and edot, things that are holy to Hashem in more obviously spiritual ways.

The Torah moves (Shemos 22:17) to laws against witchcraft: "מכשפה לא תחיה," You shall not allow a sorceress to live. Laws about not being cruel to animals (Shemos 23:5): " כי תראה חמור שנאך רבץ תחת משאו," When you see the donkey of your enemy lying under its burden. Laws about idolatry (Shemos 22:19): "זבח לאלקים יחרם," One who sacrifices to the gods shall be destroyed.

Once we have been metaken our middos, once we've refined ourselves through proper interpersonal conduct, we go through the cycle again. Back to the judges, but now from a place of elevated kavod. To terumot, giving gifts to Hashem and to others. To the laws of treifah, non-kosher animals. To basar bechalav, the prohibition of mixing milk and meat.

The parsha even culminates (Shemos 23:10-11) with shemittah, the sabbatical year: " ושש שנים תזרע את ארצך ואספת את תבואתה. והשביעת תשמטנה ונטשתה," Six years you shall sow your land and gather its produce, and in the seventh you shall release it and abandon it.

Shemittah: The Integration of All Three

Shemittah is remarkable because it combines all three categories.

It's an **edut**, a testimony—like Shabbos, it testifies that Hashem is the Creator and ultimate owner of the land. We rest the land just as Hashem rested on Shabbos.

It's a **chok**, a statute that doesn't make rational economic sense. Let the land lie fallow for an entire year? Trust that somehow there will be enough to eat? This requires faith beyond logic.

And it's also a **mishpat**, a social law, because during shemittah I am mevater on my ownership, I relinquish my claim, so that the poor can come and partake of what grows on its own. I share even when I get no credit, no recognition, no thanks. The Torah says (Shemos 23:11): " ואכלו אביני עמך," And the destitute of your people shall eat.

This is giving kavod to the land, to Eretz Yisrael. This is recognizing that it all belongs to Hashem. This is caring for those in need. All three types of mitzvos, integrated into one.

It's a Continuous Loop

This is the message of Mishpatim: it's a continuous loop, a cycle that reminds us this is part of being a Jew. Continuous growth. We always want to be moving forward, upward, in a happy, healthy direction.

The Rambam writes in Hilchos Teshuvah (7:6): "כל ימיו של אדם יהיה כבעל תשובה," All of a person's days, he should be like one who is doing teshuvah. We're never finished. We're never done growing.

Hashem gives us a beautiful framework, and in this week's parsha, after the Aseres HaDibros, this is the method: working on my lower self, how I interact with others.

We remind ourselves that how we act with others is not lower—it's necessary. It's foundational. If I am good with others, I can be good with Hashem. And so the cycle continues.

The Real Trinity

This week, I invite us all to look at ourselves and this parsha and ask:

Where am I showing proper kavod to Am Yisrael? Am I lifting others and myself up through mishpatim?

Where am I using growth in my interactions with others to help myself grow spiritually, to come closer to Hashem?

Where am I fulfilling all three types of mitzvos—bein adam lechavero, bein adam laMakom, and bein adam le'atzmo (between people, between man and God, and within myself)?

This is the real "trinity" of Judaism, if we can use that term: every Jew is a chelek Eloka mima'al mamash, literally a part of God from above. And what are we? A part of the one true Hashem.

Not three separate entities, but three dimensions of one integrated reality. Our relationship with ourselves, with others, and with Hashem are not separate compartments. They're all part of the same spiritual journey, the same cycle of growth.

When I work on myself, I improve my relationships with others. When I improve my relationships with others, I grow closer to Hashem. When I grow closer to Hashem, I understand myself better. Round and round, spiraling upward.

Reflection and Growth

As we enter Shabbos, consider:

On Bein Adam Lechavero:

- How am I treating the people I interact with daily—family, coworkers, people I do business with?
- Am I paying workers on time? Am I honest in my dealings? Am I showing basic kavod?

On the Cycle of Growth:

- Where have I elevated my "lower self" this week through proper interpersonal conduct?
- How has that enabled me to reach higher spiritually?

On Integration:

- Am I treating bein adam lechavero as less important than bein adam laMakom?
- Do I recognize that both were given at Sinai, both are equally Divine?

Closing Thought

Parshas Mishpatim teaches us that there is no separation between the spiritual and the social, between the lofty and the practical, between serving Hashem and serving His children.

By refining how we treat others, we refine ourselves. By building proper social structures, we build the foundation for spiritual growth. By recognizing that mishpatim and the Aseres HaDibros both came from Sinai, we recognize that all of life is sacred, all of our interactions matter, all of our choices have spiritual weight.

May we merit to live this cycle of growth, continuously elevating ourselves and others, spiraling upward toward Hashem, recognizing that we are all part of the one true Source.

Have an amazing Shabbos.